

Swahili Greetings and Everyday Phrases

Basic Greetings

The most common greeting in Kenya is 'Habari?', which literally means 'News?' and is used like 'How are you?'. A typical reply is 'Nzuri', meaning 'Good' or 'Fine'. Another everyday greeting is 'Hujambo?', to which the reply is 'Sijambo', meaning roughly 'I have no troubles'. Among younger people and in casual settings, 'Sasa?' or 'Niaje?' (Sheng, a Swahili-English urban slang) are common informal greetings similar to 'What's up?'.

Greeting Elders

Respect for elders is an important part of Kenyan social custom, and this is reflected in language. A common greeting from a younger person to an elder is 'Shikamoo', to which the elder responds 'Marahaba'. This greeting pattern signals deference and is still used in many communities, particularly along the coast and in more traditional settings, though 'Habari' is used more broadly across age groups.

Time-of-Day Greetings

Swahili has specific greetings tied to the time of day. 'Habari za asubuhi' means 'How is the morning?', 'Habari za mchana' means 'How is the afternoon?', and 'Habari za jioni' means 'How is the evening?'. These are commonly shortened in casual speech, but the fuller forms are still used in more formal or polite exchanges.

Common Courtesy Phrases

'Asante' means 'Thank you', and 'Asante sana' means 'Thank you very much'. 'Karibu' means 'Welcome' or 'You're welcome', and is used both when inviting someone in and when responding to thanks. 'Tafadhali' means 'Please', and 'Samahani' means 'Excuse me' or 'Sorry', used both to apologize and to politely get someone's attention.

Saying Goodbye

'Kwaheri' is the standard way to say goodbye, and 'Tutaonana' means 'We will see each other (again)', similar to 'See you later'. In casual Sheng, 'Baadaye' ('Later') is also common among younger speakers in urban areas like Nairobi.